

POLICY BRIEF

HOW PREPARED ARE AFRICAN EDUCATION SYSTEMS FOR CLASSROOM CONTENT RISKS? PERSPECTIVES FROM CAMEROON, KENYA AND ZIMBABWE



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Digital tools and social media are rapidly changing the meaning of the classroom. Students' images, voices, names, behavior, and learning experiences can now be recorded and circulated far beyond the school community, creating new risks around privacy, reputational harm, cyber-ridicule, data misuse, and permanent digital footprints. Drawing on RLRI - Africa Program field research in Cameroon, Kenya, and Zimbabwe, as well as a pan-African webinar bringing together educators, policymakers, child protection advocates, and technology experts, this policy brief examines the growing challenges at the intersection of education, technology, and child rights and offers practical recommendations for safer, more inclusive digital learning environments across Africa

Key Findings and Recommendations

Key Findings

- 1 There is a persistent gap between high-level legal commitments regarding children's digital rights and the lived realities within classrooms.
- 2 A coordinated approach is required to align legislation, enforcement and day-to-day educational practice to ensure meaningful protection of digital rights.
- 3 National governments must provide regulatory "teeth" to deter abuse, while schools must serve as the immediate "shield" protecting students from harm.
- 4 Foundational laws are necessary but insufficient unless they are translated into enforceable school-level rules on consent, recording, takedown, reporting, digital ethics and accountability.



Recommendations

- 1 Cameroon should move beyond foundational laws such as Law No. 2023/009¹ and translate them into enforceable school-level operational rules. The Ministry of Posts and Telecommunications should work with education authorities to issue specific guidance for educators on personal device use, prohibit the recording of disciplinary or emotionally charged moments, and provide parents with clear pathways for redress and content removal when a child's digital dignity is harmed.
- 2 Kenya should leverage the Data Protection Act of 2019² by issuing sector-specific guidance that requires explicit, informed parental consent for classroom recordings. Education authorities should move from reactive penalties to proactive digital-literacy campaigns that train teachers in data hygiene, viral-content risks, and cyber-extortion, while encouraging safe educational use that protects student dignity and avoids using students as props for personal brand-building.
- 3 Zimbabwe should bridge its "policy gap in plain sight" by requiring the Ministry of Primary and Secondary Education to treat classroom recording as data processing rather than informal educational documentation. Standardized protocols should require specific, time-bound and revocable parental permissions, and clear institutional reporting channels should prevent sensitive incidents from becoming "trial by social media."
- 4 Across all three countries, schools need practical rules on filming students, professional boundaries on social media, meaningful parental consent, learner-sensitive recording, takedown mechanisms and digital ethics training. Children's rights should remain the governing standard even where technology creates legitimate educational benefits.

Problem, Context & Background

The rapid expansion of digital tools and social media into school life is changing the meaning of the classroom. What was once primarily a protected space for learning, discipline, social development and teacher–learner interaction is increasingly becoming a site of digital content production.

Students’ images, voices, names, behaviour and classroom experiences may now be recorded and circulated beyond the school community, exposing children to privacy violations, reputational harm, cyber-ridicule, data misuse and permanent digital footprints.

Digital platforms can support learning, improve parent communication, showcase teaching practice and expand access to educational resources. The policy problem arises when visibility is treated as automatically beneficial without clear rules on consent, purpose, storage, sharing, removal and accountability.

This brief asks whether education systems are prepared to manage classroom-content risks while preserving the legitimate benefits of educational technology. The research combined review of national education policies, regional digital-rights legislation and institutional guidance with field observations, semi-structured interviews with educators and parents, and stakeholder dialogue through a virtual webinar.

Across Cameroon, Kenya and Zimbabwe, legal and policy instruments exist that can protect children’s privacy and online safety, including data-protection, cybercrime and child-online-protection frameworks. Yet these frameworks are often too general for everyday classroom content creation. Schools may lack practical filming protocols; teachers may be unclear about professional boundaries; parents may not fully understand what they are consenting to; and learners may feel unable to refuse recording because of the power imbalance between adults and children.



Beyond the Classroom: When School Extends into Online Space in Kenya



School is a social environment where significant interaction takes place between teachers, students and parents. Teachers have long taken pictures and videos during school trips, sports days and other activities to preserve memories and share them with families. The legal and ethical complexity grows when this content moves beyond secure school-parent networks and into public social media spaces such as TikTok, Facebook and Instagram. Kenya's Data Protection Act of 2019 requires informed parental consent before schools use children's images or videos for promotional purposes, and it requires that the processing of a child's personal data be guided by the child's best interests.² The 2023 Roma School case in Uthiru, where the school was fined for using a pupil's image without parental consent, demonstrated that these duties are enforceable.³ Yet digital teacher-influencers face additional risks: cyber threats, harassment, compromised student data and blurred professional boundaries.⁴ At the same time, educational use of social media can increase student interest and support learning.⁵ The policy challenge is therefore not to prohibit digital engagement, but to ensure that consent is meaningful, exposure is proportionate and student dignity remains protected.

An increasingly visible group of teachers has gained popularity by posting classroom interactions online—humorous exchanges, sports activities, acts of kindness and educational demonstrations. Some videos blur students' faces while others show faces clearly, use full names or make voices identifiable. Even where the online response is positive, consent is rarely visible to viewers, raising a deeper question: Does parental permission alone make this exposure safe?

The education system, therefore, needs to raise awareness of both the benefits and risks of extending school life into public online spaces. Parents, teachers and students need practical guidance so that parental consent is truly informed, teachers understand professional boundaries, and children's privacy is protected even when educational content is well-intentioned.



Assessing Preparedness to Mitigate Classroom Content Risks in Zimbabwe

The rapid digitization of Zimbabwe's education system under the "Education 5.0" model has turned classrooms into increasingly visible sites of content production. As educators repurpose learning environments for social media, students may become participants in performances that prioritize viral engagement over privacy and intellectual development.⁶ Given the inherent power imbalance between teachers and learners, student consent is especially difficult to treat as fully voluntary.

The adoption of mobile technology has outpaced the development of specialized digital governance in education.⁷ This has produced a "visibility trap" in which concentration and participation can be displaced by performance for an external audience, while students acquire permanent digital footprints they cannot control.

Zimbabwe's Cyber and Data Protection Act provides a legal basis for privacy protection,⁸ and Statutory Instrument 155 of 2024 requires explicit consent for the processing of personal data.⁹ Yet many educators still treat classroom recording as informal educational documentation rather than data processing, weakening the protections owed to minors.⁹

The Zimbabwe National AI Strategy (2026–2030) and discussions on child online protection policy create an opportunity to establish stronger safeguards.¹⁰ Recent viral school incidents have highlighted the dangers of "trial by social media," in which sensitive footage circulates before institutions can investigate or respond.¹¹ School Development Committees should therefore lead parental digital-literacy initiatives, move away from broad indemnity waivers and support centralized consent systems with specific, time-bound and revocable permissions. A Digital Professionalism Charter for educators could help distinguish legitimate pedagogy from performative exploitation and place the institution's duty of care above personal-brand incentives.



Innovation, Consent and the “Policy Gap in Plain Sight”

The policy debate is polarized between an “innovation-first” approach, which views social media as a means to make learning more relatable and showcase African teaching excellence,¹² and a rights-based protection approach that treats the classroom as a sanctuary to be shielded from extractive platform dynamics.¹³

The ethical validity of “informed consent” is complicated by structural power imbalances.¹⁴ In hierarchical school settings, students may comply with recording because they see it as an unavoidable part of the lesson rather than a genuine choice.¹⁵

A primary school teacher in Mazowe observed that students usually “just go along with it” because they view being recorded as part of the lesson.¹⁶

Participation cannot be considered truly informed if students or parents do not understand how social media algorithms extract, amplify, and retain content, or the risks of a permanent digital footprint. Educators also feel pressure to maintain a digital brand while worrying about legal consequences when the line between an educational tool and a performance becomes blurred.¹⁷ Parents may be equally constrained: some fear that refusing consent could affect their child’s treatment or relationship with a teacher.¹⁸ This dynamic turns apparently voluntary permission into a weak protection mechanism and makes centralized, transparent consent systems essential.



The push for innovation can, therefore, leave educators vulnerable and students exposed. Governance must prioritize institutional protection over social media metrics, with clear boundaries that allow legitimate digital teaching while preventing minors from being converted into involuntary content subjects.

The central policy challenge is to make consent specific, informed, revocable and safe to refuse. Schools need centralized registries, clear purpose limitations, defined retention periods, and accessible complaint or takedown pathways so that parents and learners can exercise their rights without fearing retaliation or reputational consequences.

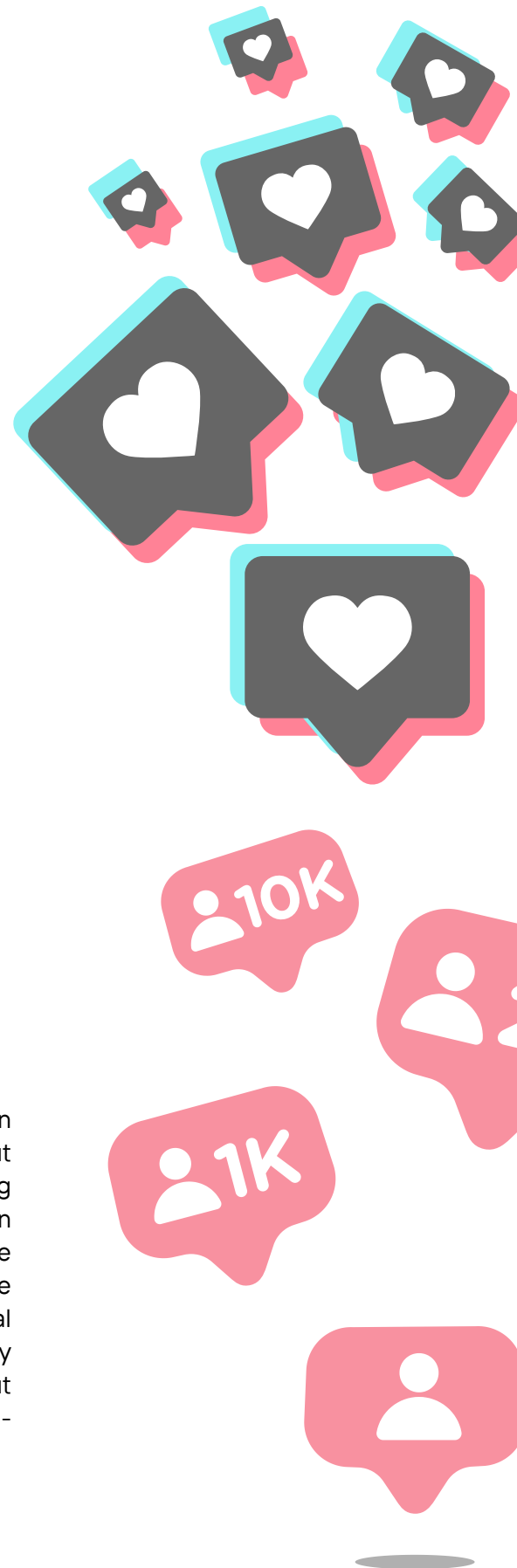
The TikTok Classroom Phenomenon in Cameroon

In Cameroon, where digital governance frameworks are still consolidating, classrooms increasingly function as TikTok content-creation spaces. The Charter on Child Online Protection (Law No. 2023/009)¹ and the Cybersecurity and Cyber-Criminality Law (No. 2010/012)¹⁹ provide a legal basis for protecting minors' data and digital dignity, but enforcement in everyday classroom settings remains limited and inconsistent.

Hashtags linked to Cameroonian teachers and school life reveal a wide spectrum of classroom content. Some videos use songs, dances and skits to engage students; others capture disciplinary or emotionally charged moments. In many clips, minors' faces are visible and unblurred, effectively turning the classroom into a semi-public stage. Educators interviewed for the study warned that moments of frustration or discipline can permanently brand a child as a "troublemaker" for a global audience.²⁰ Parents likewise described seeing school videos posted without their knowledge and not knowing how to initiate redress when content harms their child.²¹

The Ministry of Posts and Telecommunications and the National Communication Council have partnered with platforms such as TikTok on online safety,²² yet clear rules specific to classroom content remain absent. The result is a regulatory vacuum precisely where harm to minors is most likely: schools lack sector-specific guidance, parents lack meaningful consent mechanisms, and educators lack professional standards for digital conduct.

Cameroon's experience reflects a wider Sub-Saharan African pattern: foundational legal instruments are necessary but insufficient.²³ Without explicit national guidance on filming students, enforceable parental-consent protocols, restrictions on recording disciplinary or emotionally charged moments, accessible takedown pathways and digital-ethics training for educators, the classroom will remain a contested space where pedagogical innovation and child-protection risks travel side by side. The policy objective should not be to eliminate educational technology, but to make child dignity, privacy and best interests the non-negotiable conditions for its use.



Conclusion

The goal of educational policy must be to ensure that classrooms remain “sanctuaries of learning” rather than stages for content exposure. Foundational legal instruments in Kenya, Zimbabwe and Cameroon are necessary but insufficient unless translated into enforceable school-level protocols that prioritize child safety over digital visibility. By harmonizing national legislation with classroom practice—including centralized consent registries, learner-sensitive recording rules, professional standards, accessible reporting and takedown mechanisms, and mandatory digital-ethics training—education systems can reduce non-consensual data exposure while preserving legitimate educational innovation. Success should be measured not by the reach of online content, but by a demonstrable reduction in exploitation and a measurable increase in parental and learner trust.



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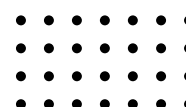
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